

tain kind of people who work well in that environment; those who are also ambitious and focussed on impact.”

Several former senior employees have complained of unrealistic deadlines, midnight working hours and a verbal abuse culture in office. “I joined the company because I was told we were building the future of mobility, but what I got in return was absolute lack of respect and an abusive work environment. Because of the pandemic, the entire focus has shifted to Ola Electric and no interest was left in changing things on the internet business side,” a former senior employee told *BT* on the condition of anonymity. “In one year, I probably aged 10 years.”

There are others who speak less harshly. “It’s a choice someone needs to make. You have to decide whether you want to be Tiger Woods or Michael Schumacher. We’re not playing golf here; we’re in Formula One. You have to be prepared for it,” another former employee says. Most former employees *BT* spoke to said that Aggarwal is detail-oriented, over ambitious and a visionary, and that working at Ola is not for everyone.

Aggarwal’s take is straightforward: “Obviously, Ola is a very ambitious company. We want to lead the industries that we’re focussed on. The culture we have is that we want to experiment, take big shots. As long as most of them succeed, we’re comfortable. If a person wants to do life-changing work, we’re the best company to do that. We question the status quo a lot more than any company. Expectation on work is in general slightly higher than other places, and so is the reward.”

THE ROAD AHEAD

Apart from getting the scooter right and also launching a sub-₹10 lakh electric car by mid-2023, Aggarwal is

DESPITE THE CHALLENGES PLAGUING THE ELECTRIC TWO-WHEELER SPACE, THE FUTURE IS BRIGHT WITH ANALYSTS PEGGING THE MARKET AT 7-8 MILLION UNITS IN FIVE YEARS

bubbling with big plans: “Our vision is to build the world’s largest two-wheeler product portfolio and manufacturing scale, sell in India, also sell in key markets like Asean, LatAm, Europe, etc., and also build cars and focus on segments relevant to India like mid-sized and small cars. We’re also setting up a very large cell innovation centre and have 100 engineers working on that because we want to control the technology. Over the next decade, we’ll see a lot of innovation, be it solid state batteries, sodium ion batteries... we’re looking to launch in two years from now and looking to build a fresh product, and also build the factory for it.”

He says that taking on legacy four-wheeler players wouldn’t be easy but he’s up for the challenge: “Absolutely, we can take on legacy four-wheeler players. Have I built a car before? No. But had we built a scooter before? No. Had we done ride hailing before? No.”

Most analysts feel that the bad days are behind Ola Electric. “Given the valuation they’re commanding and the amount of money being given to them, my bet is they’ll be able to turn it around. They will get it right eventually. That said, the thin-skinned responses and the way they have come out on PR hasn’t helped. But they’re trying out many things that will eventually be good for the

industry,” says Sengupta. “Their product is not a disaster. They can fix this with some solid engineering work. My sense is their four-wheeler plans will be delayed a bit because it makes sense to first stabilise their two-wheeler business and then get into four wheelers.”

Avalon projects the electric two-wheeler market to reach 7-8 million in five years. “Therefore, even if they hold their ground, they’ll be able to sell 700,000-800,000 vehicles just like that. They have a viable product on ground. It needs some course correction, that’s all, as long as the company is humble and willing to work with customers to resolve it,” says Sengupta. “It’s more like a blip than a long-term trend.”

Starry-eyed Aggarwal says Ola is the world’s most unique company in that it has a ride sharing business, auto retail capability, financing and insurance of vehicles, its own electric manufacturing and, now, even cell manufacturing. “The ride will always remain rough when you want to win in a big boys’ game, and that’s exactly what we’ve set out to do.”

Whether he succeeds or not, one thing is certain: Aggarwal and Ola would have turbo-charged the EV ecosystem like none other. **BT**

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